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Contents

About the project - Larpocracy 3
Acknowledgements 4
Appendices included in this deliverable 4
Executive summary 5
1. Introduction 6
Overarching Methodological Considerations 7
2. Initial Workshop 11
3. (A3.1) Iterate design of larp in an explorative design process. 13
4. (A3.2) Experimental trials with larp in a variety of settings, including leisure larp festivals, non-formal, and formal learning environments. 20
5. Insights 27
6. Moving forward 27
References and sources 27
Appendices 27
HOT SHOTS 27
BUNKER 101 27
SANDLEFORD 27
THE ASSEMBLY 27
MIDSUMMER IN WALDEN 27

About the project - Larpocracy

Larpocracy researches spaces for deliberation and democratic skill building through live-action role-playing (larp). Funded by Horizon Europe, seven leading partners will study the use of larp as a method for creating inclusive and democratic social spaces, both online and offline.

Our mission is to investigate the potential of live-action role-playing (larp) as a method to foster democratic skill building and political engagement. Our research aims to leverage this innovative form of co-creative embodied play to address declining engagement in traditional democracy and the limitations of social media in fostering civic discourse.

The project will produce:

- Studies and experiments chartering capacities of larp in supporting democratic engagement and fostering democratic skill-building.
- Public events in collaboration with designers and organisers from marginalised and vulnerable communities.
- Design exemplars of larp and larp spaces capable of supporting inclusivity and democratic engagement.
- Evidence-based Democracy by Design Toolkit.
- A widespread community of Experts understanding the capacities of larp and larp-like spaces in fostering democratic engagement.
- Evidence-based Policy Recommendations supporting policy-makers in multiple domains.

Acknowledgements

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Appendices included in this deliverable

This deliverable is accompanied by 6 appendices.

- **Appendix 1:** Larps under development as part of WP3 work
- **Appendix 2:** Theoretical Framework of Embodied Debriefing
- **Appendix 3:** Theoretical Grounding of Embodied Debriefing in Simulation Games
- **Appendix 4:** Study and Design of Parody Politician Accounts
- **Appendix 5:** *The Assembly*: Designing a Role-playing Intervention to Foster Skills in Democratic Deliberation
- **Appendix 6:** Practicing Empathy in *The Assembly*: A Mixed Methods Study of a Deliberative Larp Intervention

Executive summary

The overarching goal of WP3 is to develop design principles and recommendations for larp and larp-adjacent activities to support and develop democratic engagement. The work package develops design principles and exemplars of larp designs based on deliberative events that support democratic engagement, deliberation, and understanding.

The outcomes of the work package are expected to be of two types; design principles and design exemplars, supported by experimental and evaluative studies. This deliverable covers the methodological approach underlying the experimental design work carried out within WP3, the current state of the design projects pursued, and preliminary results from early studies carried out within the work package.

The studies in focus in this deliverable are:

- Design and assessment of the larp *The Assembly,* which was the first larp completed as part of the WP3 work
- Design and trial of a range of innovative larp 'snippets'
- Embodied debrief design studies
- Semi-controlled experiments on critical design choices
- A nethnography of political parody role-play in social media

1. Introduction

The overarching goal of WP3 is to develop design principles and recommendations for larp and larp-adjacent activities to support and develop democratic engagement. The work package develops design principles and exemplars of larp designs that support democratic engagement, discussion and understanding, including designs based on deliberative events.

The outcomes of the work package are expected to be of two types; design principles and design exemplars, supported by experimental and evaluative studies. The work package comprises of four activities:

- A3.1 Iterative design of larp in an explorative design process. Design effects are studied for scenarios of limited lengths and scales.
- A3.2 Experimental trials with Larp in a variety of settings, including leisure larp festivals, non-formal, and formal learning environments.
- A3.3 A collection of larp scenarios capable of fostering democratic engagement and deliberative skills is curated and made publicly available.
- A3.4 Analysis and writeup (documenting the activities above).

This deliverable reports on the explorative design process, which has been informed by theory development and empirical studies from WP2, including work comparing practices within role-playing games and deliberative events. The reported activities fall under A3.1 (iterative design) and A3.2 (experimental trials). Since work remains in both activities, the outcomes reported in this deliverable are preliminary and focus is put on the process and methodology, rather than on final results.

The studies in focus in this deliverable are:

- Design and assessment of *The Assembly*, which was the first larp completed as part of the WP3 work
- Design and trial of a range of innovative larp 'snippets'
- Embodied Debrief design studies
- Semi-controlled experiments on critical design choices
- A nethnography of political parody role-play in social media

Overarching Methodological Considerations

The work package is grounded in Research through Design as articulated by Redström (2017) and hence embraces a pragmatic perspective on knowledge production (Dewey 2005; Schön 1983). Taking a pragmatic foundation for the work package's research approach implies considering knowledge as manifest in practical application as much as in abstract theory.

A central assumption in WP3 is that design carries knowledge (W. Gaver 2012). Designs are knowledge contributions in themselves, as exemplars of design approaches and solutions. But design knowledge does not arise only after designs are complete and evaluated, but is generated through explorations and practical design work, in partial formulations, in successful as well as failed attempts, in design meetings, test runs, and experiments. Design does not always express an already-formed idea; it can also be a way of thinking, testing, and communicating (Schön 1983). Early design ideas 'talk back' to the designer and provides an anchor for dialogue within a design team. All steps in the process of design play a part in the gradual sharpening of the understanding of a design problem and its innovative solutions. D3.1 therefore needs to treat not only final evaluations but also process traces and designed artefacts at various stages of completion as part of the evidence.

The work package still takes a theory-informed approach. It starts its understanding of deliberative theory from the groundwork laid in WP2 (Bowman and Szatkowska 2026). Deliberative theory has informed this work as a set of orienting questions and tensions, and deliberative practices have informed the design of the event structure for *The Assembly*. The design work repeatedly returns to issues such as legitimacy, disagreement, voice, civic skills, emotional investment, conflict handling, and the conditions under which people can remain in relation to one another even when they do not agree (Bowman, Öberg, Johansson, et al. 2026).

Practically, the overarching empirical methodology for WP3 is experimental game design (Back and Waern 2015). Experimental game design involves making multiple designs, or multiple versions of the same design, and studying what happens when they are put to use. This process is already present in the design practice for larp in how short larps are almost always test-run at least once, and then modified, before they are considered finished. However, research through design is a scholarly practice which puts higher requirements on the process of design. In particular, higher demands are put on 1) articulating the motivations for engaging in a particular design endeavour, 2) rigor in process documentation including evaluations and studies, and 3) rigor in documentation of resulting designs (Höök and Löwgren 2012). The design processes carried out within WP3 aim to be thoroughly documented in all steps.

Waern and Back (IBID) distinguishes between three forms of experimental game design. These are controlled experiments, evocative experiments, and experiments that explore a game genre. Controlled experiments require highly controlled runs with variants of the same game, aiming to understand the effects of specific design choices. Evocative experiments focus on innovative design options and explore their opportunities and potential issues in a rapid design-and-evaluation cycle. Finally, experiments can be done to explore a genre, but this requires that full game designs are run

under real or realistic conditions, that permit capturing player reactions through observation and player's subjective accounts.

- A few controlled and semi-controlled design experiments are included in the work package, focussed on specific and critical design choices for deliberative larp. These are done as part of A3.2 Experimental trials with Larp in a variety of settings.
- The design of 'larp snippets' and their development closely follows the principle of evocative design experiments. Their role is to explore innovative design ideas that can widen the design space for larp capable of fostering democratic engagement. This work forms the core of the work in *A3.1. iterative design of larp in an explorative design process*. The work also includes explorations of larp debrief and integration design, and studies of a particular genre of online role-play.
- The work on *The Assembly* in particular, but also several of the larp snippets, serve to formulate and explore a larp genre called *deliberative larp*. The experiments run to this purpose are reported as part of *A3.2 Experimental trials with larp in a variety of settings*. Trials of *The Assembly* have been executed in formal, non-formal, and informal learning environments to capture player reactions under different conditions, with data collection and analysis ongoing. This study follows a psychological approach to researching educational interventions, featuring a mixed method longitudinal study design based upon the draft Framework for Effects Assessment developed in WP2.

2. Initial Workshop

The work started with a conceptualization workshop, focussed on identifying knowledge gaps in design for democratic engagement and skill building in larp. The workshop centred around two questions: first what opportunities has the work in Larpocracy identified, and secondly classifying design opportunities into three areas: 1) those that were considered well explored in existing larps, and 2) already ongoing work (some of it in WP2), and 3) identified opportunities that were underexplored.

The four identified opportunities were

1. Teach people to participate in deliberative processes.
2. Triggering change of view / and or behaviour.
3. Reflect over one's view of democracy.
4. Understanding of others' perspectives



Figure 1: Map of experimental design opportunities identified in the workshop.

3. (A3.1) Iterate design of larp in an explorative design process.

The Larp Snippet Approach

WP3 is a collaboration between larp designers and academics and thus bridges multiple ways of knowing and talking about design. Where academics often work through concepts and distinctions, generating knowledge through articulation, practitioners often work through concrete examples, generating knowledge through skilled readings of the examples and the experience of designing them.

To bridge these modes of thinking and articulation, the team relied on a deliberately neutral, under-defined, and low-prestige concept created within the project, called "larp snippets". Members of the design team were tasked with creating short, playable, micro-versions of key design choices. These were presented, played, and discussed within a very limited time frame, usually a maximum of ten minutes of presentation and setup and ten minutes of gameplay. The snippets were not expected to function as good or complete larps in their own right; instead, they were meant to act as conveyers of non-verbalized knowledge. Their compact playable form helped communicate ideas between collaborators, make partially formed intuitions discussable, and create a shared basis for reflection. The snippet format made it possible to externalize ideas quickly, play through them in an embodied form, and then discuss what seemed to work, fail, provoke, or resonate. In this sense, snippets were not miniature finished games but rather a form of language, or structured prompts for inquiry.

Many of the snippets feature some form of democratic deliberation and thus help to map out the design space of larp featuring deliberation. Adopting a fluid and iterative process allows the project to challenge existing design practices and find paths toward design innovation.

Additionally, some of the larps in the project, notably *The Assembly and Dobro Wspolne,* were designed based on theory and practice in deliberative events from the political science literature. These can be called *deliberative larps.* These are educational larp with explicit learning objectives, and build on empirical research in WP2 comparing larp to deliberative events. Their structures and mechanics build on the possible positive effects of combining larp with deliberative event structures. This is further discussed under *A3.2 Experimental trials with larp in a variety of settings.*

In practical terms, the larp design in WP3 has been organized through recurring design meetings, workshop-based ideation, scenario drafting, playtests, run-specific reflection, and ongoing comparison between cases. The design work has been documented unevenly but still substantially: through design diaries, scenario archives, meeting notes, test notes and data, runtime reflections, pitches for the Larpocracy anthology, evaluation-planning documents and evaluative data. This means that the evidence base of the larp design is a layered archive where different documents do different kinds of work. Scenario scripts show what was built; diaries and meeting notes show why it was built that way; test notes show where the design resisted or surprised its makers; and study discussions show how later evaluative work is being prepared.

After these initial designs are produced, they are playtested within the WP3 team as a whole. When possible, playtests are arranged for all members of the consortium and Domain Expert Panel to join if available, e.g., at in-person project symposia or online playtests.

Larp snippets under exploration

Several design explorations have been initiated based on the identified themes. At the time of writing, some of these are still at a very early stage.

- *The Assembly* (Theme 1, 2 and 3), discussed further below.
- Sandleford, a larp about living with democratic decisions. (Theme 3)
- *The Mountain Code #8*, a card-based larp that explores being convinced by others and changing one's minds on a subject as a result. (Theme 2)
- *Hot Shots* explores how deliberation becomes enacted in larp when it is not possible to 'win' the discussion. (Theme 1)
- *The Googoo Gaga Frontier* – A non-verbal larp that explores power relations and non-verbal deliberation, in which players are called upon to portray intelligent infants during a pillow fort fight. (Themes 1, 3)
- *Irasshaimase* – A larp about democratic participation and volunteering, based on community and food. (Themes 1, 3)
- *Juror's Stand* – A larp inspired by the movie 12 Angry Men, where the players play as Jurors, attempting to find their own place in the democratic process. (Theme 1)
- *Designer's Catwalk* – A pervasive larp, with themes of fashion, design and democratic decision making. (Theme 1)
- *Seeds* – Near-apocalyptic larp where a team of survivors have reached a space station and can send a number of people to nearby habitable planets, as seeds for new settlements. (Themes 2, 3)
- *The Battle of Nottingham Forest* – Robin Hood and the captain of the Sheriff's Guard get hurt, so both sides need to retreat behind trenches, and the people of each team need to decide what to do. (Themes 1, 2, 4)
- *Locus, Matrix, Stratum* – A larp that plays in two phases: The first one is an abstract larp in which the players create a lost civilization of the past and role-play the time between its creation and its destruction. During the game, they will craft items of symbolic or practical importance to their civilization's everyday lives. The second phase of the game engages the broad audience and takes place after the first part is concluded – a small "exhibition" of the artifacts that were created during the game. (Themes 3, 4)

Of these, *The Assembly* and *Sandleford* have been fully developed and are under evaluation. In addition, some of the larps used as part of Larpocracy studies have been developed with external

partners or volunteers. These have typically not gone through the snippet design process as this requires synchronization with project activities. In this report we touch upon two such projects:

- *Midsummer in Walden*: A larp about democracy and renewal – imagines a midsummer celebration in which luminaries of the Transcendentalist movement come together to discuss spirituality, politics, ecology, social responsibility, and the purpose of life. Activities include guided meditations, embodied movement, and deliberations over social responsibility during antebellum America. This larp is developed in collaboration with external artists.
- *Dobro Wspolne*, designed in collaboration with a Social Innovation Incubator in Poland, has been run 4 times in high schools, involving 96 players and with 7 teachers who aimed to apply it as a teaching tool. The game was designed as a tool for multicultural dialogue and to train deliberation skills among people with different values and needs.

See *Appendix 1* for a brief description of (most of) the larps and larp snippets developed in the work package or incorporated in its studies.

Explorations of embodied debriefing for democratic reflection and skill-building

The larp snippet approach is complemented by studies focused on known design challenges. The first relates to a critical issue in educational larp design, namely how we can improve the likelihood that a larp experience has a transformative effect that stretches beyond the moment. While short term effects are well documented, it remains difficult to know if they foster lasting change in the form of new competencies, knowledge, or attitudes. The process of incorporating a new experience so that it becomes a thriving part of one's identity is referred to as *integration*. Integration can happen after any transformative experience, not just a larp or a game, and it consists of a mix of conscious integrative activities, and unconscious processes. Hence, it is a complex, highly entangled and unpredictable process due to interplay of biological aspects, social interactions, life experiences and conscious self-development as personality is a dynamic system.

Debrief design has long been understood as a crucial aspect of educational game design (Crookall 2014), and has also become an established practice in educational larp (Brown 2019). Playful experiences such as larping and gaming, even when meaningful, do not necessarily become transformative in the sense that some aspects of the experience are integrated into everyday life. The process of contextualizing the experience in everyday life typically only starts once the experience itself is over. The debrief is the moment of that process which the larp designer is still in control.

Hence, WP3 has initiated a design exploration of the design of embodied larp debriefs, as an integral part of the design of larp. This exploration focusses on extending verbal debriefing, which focuses primarily on processing cognitive, emotional, and educational content through discussion, with embodied activities. Embodied debriefing leverages the physical and situated experience of participants to more effectively integrate educational experiences and access subconscious layers, fostering self-growth and post-experience participation (Szatkowska et al. 2026). In embodied

debriefing, the body is a source of information about the self, a tool to process experiences, and an agent in rehearsing newly acquired skills.

While debrief activities need to be tailored to the experience at hand, previous research has pointed towards a commonality in how they need to be structured, as well as specific elements that enhance their capability to support integration. Hence, studying debriefs in provides a key towards more broadly applicable guidelines for larp design to foster democratic engagement. Furthermore, it should be noted that designed debriefs can be part of the learning process for a range of activities outside of larp. Hence, the design of embodied debriefing deserves to be an object of further study in Larpocracy.

Preliminary results show that while the objectives underlying a larp design influence the design of its debrief, there are commonalities in how debriefs are best structured and facilitated. Furthermore, as the same larp often can be run for different reasons, the same larp can be followed by different debriefs depending on the context and purpose of running the larp. An initial analysis of existing embodied debrief practices identified 101 examples of activities that extended the practice with non-verbal elements along 7 distinctive categories: body work, somatic inquiry, movement, writing, performance, art-making, and tactile activities (see Appendix 2).

Debriefing practices can be divided into two main branches: self-oriented (learning about the self) and outside-oriented (sharing experiences among groups of participants). These approaches represent two different philosophical traditions. The approaches enhance different aspects of integration such as comprehending complex concepts, dealing with emotional load, or questioning personal worldviews. This work will be published in a book *Simulation and Gaming for Societal Change: Connecting Scientific Foundations, Practice, and Emerging AI Technologies* (Kikkawa et al., *forthcoming*).

Nethnography of role-play in social media

Rather than engaging directly with new forms of larp, in this study we instead examine an existing but under-explored genre of role-play on social media, with the aim of eliciting design principles that can later feed into the WP7 Democracy by Design toolkit. The study was initiated in a master thesis in Human Computer Interaction at Uppsala University, studying parody politician accounts on X (Feng 2026).

Previous research on parody politician accounts has largely treated them as misinformation and an authenticity problem, asking how such accounts should be detected and labelled. This study instead re-examines PPAs through a play lens, following Sicart's account of play as contextual, appropriative, and disruptive (Sicart 2014), and Hutcheon's understanding of parody as "repetition with difference" (Hutcheon and Valdés 2000). In this view, account operators play by appropriating political material and platform features to perform a political persona, while audiences play through how they take up or resist that performance.

The study used qualitative netnography combined with frame analysis (Goffman 1974) to examine 14 English-language parody-politician accounts through 241 posts and their associated audience

comments from a range of political contexts (including the UK, USA, Russia, Canada, South Africa, and North Korea) and persona types (current, former, fictional, and symbolic politicians).

The analysis shows that parody politician accounts turn politicians' public statements into an unstable play frame through selective, rather than complete, impersonation: operators imitate enough of the original persona's profile, stance, and rhetorical style to be recognisable, then deliberately play against it, through strategies ranging from voicing the accusations a politician would normally deny, to quietly tweaking their statements, to pushing their logic toward absurdity, to sustained fictional world-building. Some viewers recognise the parody and play along, extending it through memes, borrowed logic, or persona-specific forms of address, while others recognise it but decline to play, ranging from distanced appreciation to outright rejection, and others do not recognise it as parody at all, which sometimes triggers other audience members to repair the frame, and sometimes escalates it into a mocking.

Three findings follow from this: 1) parody politician accounts actively construct parody by curating authentic material alongside parodic content. This places parody in relation to the political material it references, and makes the critical distance between the playframe and primary framework more visible, 2) audiences who oppose the account's political stance have markedly limited access to the play frame, since defending the parody as "just a joke" is also a way of dismissing their objections, and 3) the playful interactivity itself is fragile, easily disrupted as deliberate and unintended misrecognition become tangled together. The three findings have been developed into three design suggestions for playful interactivity on social media, each illustrated with a design example.

1) *Designing for critical bouncing* treats the adjacency between original and parody content as a design resource, for example through feed or thread formats that let users compare perspectives side by side.

2) *Designing for playful opposition* treats parody as an open-ended prompt rather than a finished statement, making space for audience contributions to be incorporated.

3) *Designing for sustainable play* proposes more explicit ludic markers to help audiences recognise when they are inside the play frame.

Based on these suggestions, a set of account profile-page prototypes have been designed and evaluated in design critique workshops; to build a better understanding of how they are perceived and to further develop the underlying ideas. The work is currently being written up as a full-length paper, targeting ACM Designing Interactive Systems (DIS). (see Appendix 4)

4. (A3.2) Experimental trials with larp in a variety of settings, including leisure larp festivals, non-formal, and formal learning environments.

The purpose of the experimental trials is to evaluate the effectiveness of larp as tools for fostering democratic engagement and skill building. Since larps usually have more specific goals, the experiments evaluate the larps against their respective purposes and design goals, in particular, desired educational impacts on participants. When possible, the experimental trials make use of the survey instruments, observational protocols, and interview guides developed in WP2 but will sometimes streamline or modify them to align with the goals of the respective larps or the needs of specific target groups.

Long-Term Study of *The Assembly*

At the time of producing this report, one larp has been made accessible for short- and long-term evaluations. *The Assembly* (Bowman, Öberg, Rydberg, et al. 2026), a 4-hour larp, was the first completed larp developed within Larpocracy. It is primarily intended as an educational larp to train skills in deliberation. In *The Assembly*, participants are guided through a fictive citizen's assembly event, taking roles as ordinary citizens who have been asked to deliberate on the potential decriminalization or legalization of the drug psilocybin for medical, spiritual, or recreational use. The participants deliberate, then try to find consensus on recommendations to give to the Swedish Parliament. The game features a workshop, approx. 2 hours of playing, and a debrief based on learning objectives related to deliberative skill building, listening, and empathy.

The design of *The Assembly* was guided by an extensive background research process, including desk research and interviews with deliberation research experts. Individuals were also interviewed who had experience designing, facilitating, and/or participating in larp and deliberative events. *The Assembly* also builds on the conceptual basis from exploring political larp in the Nordic countries (Johansson et al. 2025) and mapping the design terrain between live action role-playing games and deliberative events in WP2 (Bowman, Öberg, Johansson, et al. 2026).

Background research emphasized comparing the structures of these events and the major considerations for facilitation/moderation, such as how to ensure safety and inclusivity. Insights from this work informed the design of the larp, which is described in Bowman et al. (in press), an award-winning paper presented at the International Simulation and Gaming Association (ISAGA) Conference in 2026 (Appendix 5).

The Assembly premiered at the Stockholm Scenario Festival in November 2025 and has been run a total of 12 times including in-person in Sweden, Germany, Finland, and Poland; online runs over Zoom; and one virtual reality run; with more runs planned for Fall 2026. The larp has been run with different target groups, including:

1. **Informal education:** 6 runs at larp festivals and online events with primarily larp players;
2. **Non-formal education:** 1 run for cultural workers and librarians from Region Uppsala, Gävleborg, and Stockholm;
3. **Formal education:** 5 runs in higher education:
    a. 2 with mixed groups of experienced larpers and non-larper students and teachers from the Departments of HCI and Law at Uppsala University, and
    b. 3 with non-larper undergraduate student groups. 1 session was with participants from Kyoto, Heidelberg, and Strasbourg University. 2 sessions featured participants at University of Gdańsk summer schools, on academic leadership and democratic values respectively.

The evaluation of *The Assembly* includes gathering both observation, survey, and interview data at 4 time points (see Figure 2). Surveys are gathered during T1 before the larp, T3 directly after the larp, and T4 at 3 months after the larp. Survey instruments focus on characterizing the players with the goal of noticing potential changes and include the demographic s and political involvement surveys (T1), the Interpersonal Reactivity Index (IRI) (Keaton 2017; Davis 1980) (T1, T4); the Deliberative Civic Values Index (DCVI) (Jennstål et al. 2021) (T1, T3, T4); and the Intrinsic Motivation Inventory (IMI) (Ryan and Deci 2000).

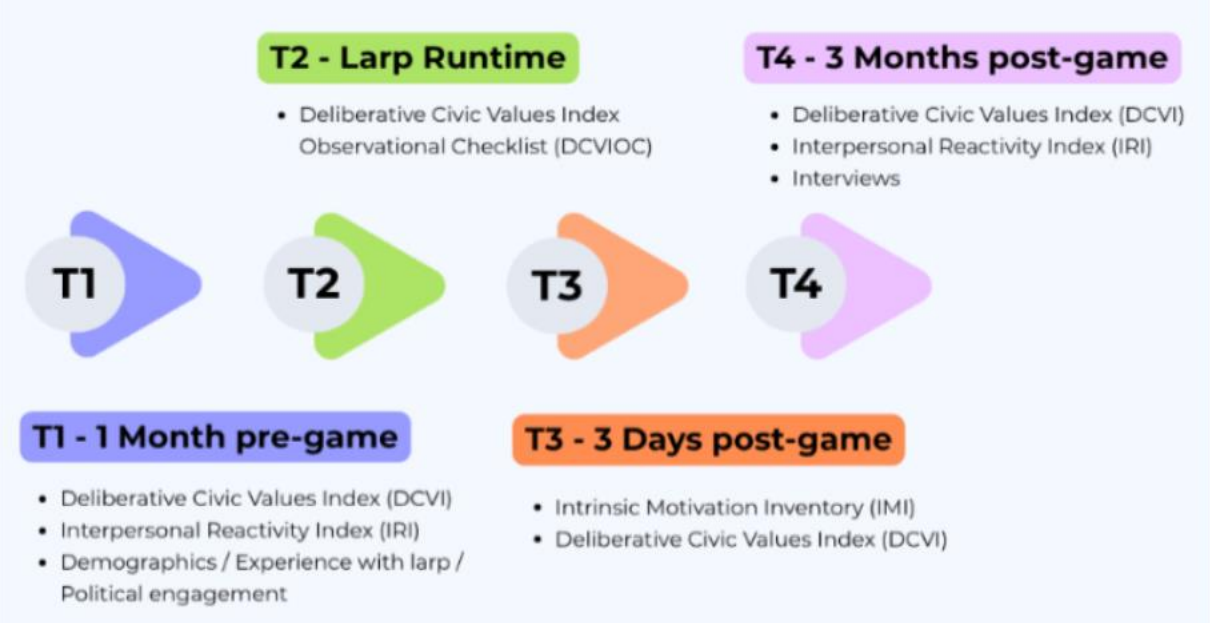


Figure 2: *Longitudinal data collection on The Assembly based on the Framework for Effects Assessment*

Observational data is taken at T2 (if permitted by ethical approval in the host country) using the Deliberative Civic Values Index Observational Checklist (DCVIOC), a tool developed in the project (Feng et al. 2026). Interviews are gathered at T4, which should be at least 3 months after the larp and ideally more than 6. For details about the specific instruments used, see Deliverable 2.1.

This practice of longitudinal data analysis allows us to understand something of the long-term effects of participating in the larp, complementing the interview and survey-based studies in WP2, which only covered 1 time point at least 6 months after a larp experience. Mixed method data from one run has been analyzed from all 4 time points with an emphasis on empathy development, reported in Tismanariu, Gardner, and Ciubotaru's (Tismanariu et al. 2026) Master's thesis, which has been adapted into a peer-reviewed article with members of the consortium and accepted for publication in a Routledge anthology and (Tismanariu et al. In press). The study found that rather than producing immediate opinion change, the larp created opportunities for situated empathic engagement that fostered reflective political thinking and a broader awareness of deliberation as a relational and affective practice. The study also examines specific design features that cultivate "empathy for the other side" and political reflection. A larger study is planned to analyze data from all runs, with data gathering in progress.

Finally, researchers in WP3 plan to apply a discourse mapping method to the rhetoric captured in online runs of The Assembly, comparing these rhetorical moves with data from the observational checklists for these runs. While the longitudinal study focuses on effects of the larp on participants before and after the game, discourse mapping allows the project to assess the degree of deliberative skill building taking place during run-time. This work will evaluate the degree to which individual character opinions change over time during the larp, as well as any trends toward de-polarization in the character group as a whole. Such data allows the project to observe skill building in situ and assess whether or not learning objectives were met more concretely.

Controlled Design Experiments

This research activity focuses on clarifying the consequences of specific design choices that emerge in larp design that aims to incorporate deliberative activities. The work is done through comparative experiment setups that are analysed both qualitatively and quantitatively. In general, such studies are difficult to incorporate in design research and can only address very limited and specific questions. The approach is resource-consuming, and the generalizability of such recommendations can always be questioned as the results can be highly dependent on the choice of larps which were explored, the backgrounds of the participants, and other situational factors. Hence, the approach has been taken only for a few, identified, design challenges that designers face but where the consequences are unclear.

Based in the groundwork on larp and deliberation performed in WP2 (in particular, interviews with facilitators of larp and civic deliberation events), we identified questions worth exploring in this way. The selected questions are

- How does the alignment between the players' perspective on democracy and that of the character, affect the player's ability to engage in deliberative dialogue in game?
- How does the seriousness of the topic being discussed affect how players engage in deliberative dialogue?

Preparatory work on these questions was done in the form of two Master thesis projects at Uppsala University. Both projects involved setting up a comparative experiment in which the same larp was run under slightly different conditions. The larps used in these experiments were designed by the students to present ideal conditions for a comparison, rather than to be engaging larps in themselves. Furthermore, in order to gather a sufficient number of data points and still allow for a complete analysis, both larps needed to be very short (15 minutes long) and run with very small groups (2-3 people). They were run online (over zoom) and the sessions were recorded and players interviewed. This setup provided functioning conditions for a mix of qualitative and quantitative analysis.

Preliminary results from these experiments show that both questions have interesting answers that can serve to inform design of future deliberative larp. When it comes to the first question, the alignment between player and character seemed to affect cognitive load. Players had longer response time and reported feeling overwhelmed by playing characters that differed from their own stance. More work is needed to understand if it also affects their ability to engage in a deliberative manner, but it is likely that the higher cognitive load can affect players' ability to listen in to the other characters' opinions and needs (Al Khatib 2026).

Concerning the second question, the seriousness of the topic seemed to primarily affect players' ability to engage socially. A serious topic created a sense of urgency and a focus on finding solutions quickly, particularly when paired with a crisis scenario that was time sensitive, whereas player deliberations tended to be more social and more relaxed and also touching on a wider range of topics when the topic was more casual (Leśniewska and Pedersen 2026). As this question is more difficult to separate from the overall design of the larp it needs to be verified with alternative designs and may require testing under more realistic conditions. One of the key factors of the research in WP2 identified that makes deliberation more effective is having an adequate amount of time to build trust in the group and a shared understanding of the topic at hand (Bowman, Öberg, Johansson, et al. 2026). Furthermore, crisis scenarios may make future-oriented thinking more challenging, as the focus on the scene is immediate concerns (Bowman and Szatkowska 2026). Short deliberations, especially with time pressure applied, may not produce the ideal conditions for quality deliberative discussion. Additional experiments to test these questions would help us better understand these aspects, e.g., with longer deliberation time, outside of crisis conditions, etc.

Both results thus need to be verified with additional experiments and a more in-depth analysis of the data. The work will continue during the autumn of 2026.

Plans for further trials

The extensive evaluation process put in place for *The Assembly* will not be used for the larp snippets, nor for finished larps building on these. Instead, simplified methods will be used focussing on short-term effects, and only a subset of the evaluation tools will be selected, adapted to the goals of each design.

There are multiple reasons for this. Firstly, the research through design approach requires that designs are iterated over the course of the project. While this is a way to verify that the designs are innovative contributions, it also takes time for the design to become stable enough to allow for a long-term study; time that the project does not allow. Longitudinal data collection adds at least 4–7 months to this process, with the aim of capturing longer-term effects on participants and reflection over time.

Secondly, the resources in the project are limited and the type of extensive evaluation initiated for *the Assembly* are simply not feasible for all designs. In particular, access to participants becomes an issue for this type of larp evaluations. In order to assemble a sufficient player base for the evaluations, *The Assembly* has been staged 12 times total both within and outside the project (in collaboration with other universities), with more runs planned.

WP3 is collaborating with a Social Innovation Incubator to in Poland, to explore the option of doing a long-term evaluation of *Dobro Wspolne.* The release of the instructions and the dissemination of the game in city libraries and high schools is planned for September.

5. Insights

The design and evaluation work carried out during the first year has produced insights that cut across the individual studies reported above. They inform both the continued design work in WP3, and the work moving forward into WP7.

Larp is not a uniform genre

Larp is not a single design category, but spans several distinct forms, some of them more well defined than others. At a minimum, we can separate between edu-larp (designed around explicit learning objectives), leisure larp (played primarily for the sake of playing), and larp-adjacent activities, often in the form of art or theatre, are inspired by and share larp's participatory, embodied character, without being larp proper. Design choices, and the effects a design can reasonably be expected to produce, differ across these categories, so treating "larp" as a uniform design target risks flattening those differences, or worse, making design suggestions fit none.

The portfolio built so far in WP3 illustrates the point but also its current limits. The Assembly and Sandleford are both edu-larp, built around explicit learning objectives and are evaluated accordingly. The netnography of parody-politician accounts sits at the larp-adjacent end. The study deliberately explores "an existing, under-explored genre of role-play" on social media that is text-based rather than embodied, and its design suggestions are aimed at generating playful interactivity on the social media platform and is not at larp design. Leisure larp currently appears mainly in larp snippets and in games being tested in leisure larp venues, such as the Stockholm Scenario Festival and MyPoint.

That asymmetry is itself an insight: design principles drawn only from edu-larp risk under-representing how leisure larp and larp-adjacent forms might each engage with democracy differently. Deliberately including examples across all three categories will need to be prioritized, and while edu-larp may have been overrepresented at the beginning of the work package, the collection curated under A3.3 will also include leisure-larp. This complements WP2's D2.2 work, which applied principles of democratic deliberation to leisure larp design and play experiences (Bowman and Szatkowska 2026) so as to synthesize recommendations for designers wanting to more precisely train deliberative skills and values in future design, which are educational objectives.

Participation and agency

There is some commonality across most larp and larp genres, that affect how democracy tends to be explicated within the format. Larp rely on embodied role-taking, an aspect that underpins one of the central types of learning that larp offer, we may learn about a variety of human experiences through walking in other people’s shoes (Johansson et al. 2026) (even if a larp experience can never fully let us understand the experience of another person).

The way in which democracy gets enacted in larp however seem to be more closely tied to how larp relies on active participation from all players. In larp, you take part in the unfolding story rather than just observing it or being told about it. A consequence of this is that players are bestowed with at least some level of agency – and often quite extensive – in shaping not only their own experience but how parts of the larp plays out. In larp, players always have something they actually can do within the story: choices and actions available not just to a character but to the player. The findings in WP2 show that a sense of agency is often central to the experiences that players report as related to democracy. Of the categories listed in the analysis framework for democratic activities developed in the work package (Bowman and Szatkowska 2026) (Appendix 6) the categories decision-making, collaboration, creating and design, protest and resistance, sharing, and organizing all relate to activities that can instil a sense of agency, especially within a group setting. The remaining categories relate to verbal communication, listening and understanding, and learning, also important to group dynamics, as well as helping lift other people so they too can have agency within the social dynamic. Thus, agency within larp is fundamentally collaborative and co-creative due to the nature of the medium and also underlies the suggestion from WP4 that larp spaces can function as autonomous zones and self-organized counter-culture (Koljonen et al. 2026).

However, from a design perspective it is important to distinguish that sense of agency from the agency that players actually are offered by design. Agency is not unlimited in larps; it is often seriously constrained, nudged, or primed toward certain kinds of actions and emotional outcomes. Designers build situations into their design that are intended to elicit particular emotions through action. To do so, they create paths of actions that the player not just need to follow but even will *want* to follow as they provide for interesting experiences and strong emotions.

The combination of a sense of participation and agency with intense emotion effects is potent. The emotion is experienced by the player as authentically their own (or their characters'), arising from something they themselves did. This happens even if that action was carefully designed and put in their path, to encourage exactly that feeling. This can be a considerably stronger way of creating emotions in players than telling or showing them something, because it does not present itself as designed at all.

This strength cuts both ways, it can be used to deliberately to produce feelings in accordance with leisure players wishes, or an edu-larp's stated learning goal. But the same mechanism does not distinguish between a change of mind a player would endorse on reflection and one they would not: used carelessly, or maliciously, without the player's awareness, it is just as capable of influencing someone against their will. That is a design and research responsibility WP3 needs to hold onto, it is part of why the debriefs and longer-term evaluation likely matter even more than measurement instruments. They are also where a strongly induced emotional experience is handed back to the player's own reflective control.

At the same time, designers can only create conditions for such experiences. The agency afforded by larp is notoriously difficult to control in practice, which is both a limitation and a strength of the form when considering larps as spaces for civic education.

Widening what "engaging with democracy" in larp can mean

The most common approach to designing democratic themes in larp build on a comparatively narrow understanding of democracy: chiefly as institutions and procedures to be simulated, or as anti-democratic oppressive structures to revolt against. Part of WP3's contribution is to provide a wider space of options for how to engage with democratic challenges as well as to design elements of democracy into their games.

Tools for learning and integration

A well-designed democratically themed larp experience does not, on its own, guarantee that something is learned, or carried forward into everyday life. In Larpocracy, we want players to reflect on their experiences and emotions, making it possible to learn from larp, and giving players a way to deliberately manage their own learning and integration, rather than having change simply happen to them. This has mainly been addressed through debrief design studies. As a designed emotional experience lands as the player's own doing, players do not, by default, know when or how they have been influenced. Embodied debriefing addresses this by giving players tools to look back at what happened to them and become aware of it, thereby making it possible to learn from larp, but also for consciously managing your own learning and integration.

6. Moving forward

Evaluations

As discussed above, evaluations are in progress for *The Assembly,* using a setup that also allows for a study of long-term effects across a dozen or more runs of the larp.

The work on snippets is also moving towards its evaluation phase. Evaluations will also be done for a selected subset of the snippets, using a relaxed approach focussed on short-term experiences and effects and parts of the spectrum of settings (formal, non-formal or informal). The selection of snippets brought towards evaluation will be done based on their innovative contribution as well as their audience and accessibility for evaluation. The selected snippets will also need to be developed into full versions incorporating debrief and integration designs.

As part of the evaluation of results from WP3, we aim to assess the designs in multiple educational environments: informal, non-formal, and formal. This is taken into consideration when planning both short- and long-term evaluations, so that we get a spread of target audiences and contexts over the planned evaluations. In particular, the *Assembly* aims for widely scoped testing over all three environments.

- As informal environments, the primary venues are larp festivals. *The Assembly* has been run at the Stockholm Scenario Festival in Sweden, at MyPoint in Poland, and at the Immersion Larp festival in Finland. *Sandleford* has run at the Knutpunkt conference in Sweden and at MyPoint. It is also desirable to find informal learning environments where the larps can be evaluated by audiences that are not familiar with the artform. To this purpose, *Sandleford* has been run with a local adult education centre in Gottsunda outside of Uppsala.
- As non-formal environments, we primarily target professional settings. *The Assembly* has been run with librarians and cultural educators from Region Uppsala, Gävleborg, and Stockholm in Sweden, and more runs are planned.
- As formal education, we primarily focus on researchers and students at the higher education level with a focus on Uppsala University. *The Assembly* has been run for researchers and students in the Human-Computer Interaction and Law departments at Uppsala University and at two summer schools at the University of Gdańsk in Poland. Another run in Germany was organized for students from the universities of Strasbourg, Kyoto, and Heidelberg.

Design experiments

As discussed above, some work is still ongoing with controlled experiments on specific design questions for deliberative larp. In addition, the work on embodied debriefing will include a semi-controlled experiment comparing different approaches to embodied debriefing to each other.

From snippets to nuggets

The larp snippets described earlier carry design knowledge, but largely implicit, partly in themselves, but mostly in how they are played, in the playtest notes, and in reflections and design-meeting discussions around them. To make that knowledge accessible also beyond those directly involved, WP3 is developing a method for moving from internal knowledge in larp snippets to explicated knowledge in what the project calls *design nuggets*.

The nuggets builds on established forms of intermediate-level design knowledge (Löwgren 2013). First, annotated portfolios (B. Gaver and Bowers 2012), where annotations articulate what a collection of (artifact) designs share and where they differ. Once annotated, the set of snippets is intended to function as such a portfolio for the activity design knowledge those snippets contain. Further, it is inspired by gameplay design patterns (Björk and Holopainen 2005), semi-formal descriptions of recurring design solutions that support both analysis and new design. Nuggets are similar to pattern in that they are semi-generalised design knowledge that emerges from one or several snippets and refers back to them as examples. Where gameplay design patterns mainly describe game structures and how mechanics interact, nuggets concern the design of activity more broadly; how a larp shapes what participants do and experience together. A nugget may for example take the form of a mechanic, a framing move, a role relation, a facilitation technique or a debrief structure, as long as it can function as a tool to entice a specific game activity.

At the time of writing, the snippets are documented but not yet annotated in a form suitable for external presentation, and while informally discussed, no nuggets have been identified yet. Two of the candidate nuggets that are being explored are:

- *Deliberation with a known outcome*, which emerged as *The Sacrifice* was revised into *Hot Shots*. The outcome of the game is settled off-game beforehand, and known to the players, while the characters play as if it was still undecided. This removes the winning condition and shifts play towards the deliberation itself.
- *Playing after the decision is made* is explored in *Sandleford*, where voting and descision making is removed from play altogether; the game concerns what happens afterwards, and its outcome deals with how each character handles the situation, and what they make out of it, rather than on the decision as such, thereby using democracy as a setting instead of as a game tool.

During autumn 2026 and early spring 2027, the WP3 team will assemble and annotate the snippet portfolio, extract candidate nuggets, and develop a format that is formal enough to be shared and used, but open enough not to become too rigid to use. Nuggets will be validated mainly through presentation and discussion, by relating them to each other, and by inviting designers within and outside the work package to comment on their usefulness. This tests whether nuggets are recognizable and usable as design knowledge, not necessarily whether they produce the intended effects in play; which will have to be left for future work. The results will feed into the WP7 Democracy by Design toolkit and into external publications. The relation to the design cards presented below remains open; nuggets may come to function as tools within or directly related to that system.

Method development: Design cards

This work builds directly on the identification of existing design strategies for designing larp democracy that has been done in WP2, and the perceived lack of engagement with political theory in common approaches to larp design (Waern et al. 2026).

The design cards are intended to support larp designers in engaging more widely with democratic theory, opening opportunities for designing narratively interesting larps that are democratically themed. Rather than presenting democracy as institutions, procedures, or abstract values, the deck provides designers with democratic dilemmas and activities that can be turned into playable situations, conflicts, relationships, and actions. This approach is based on the idea that larps are emotion engines, while most democratic-themed larps have a tendency towards implementing simulations of democratic systems.

The cards are developed in a similar process as the larps in WP3. Their exploration concerns how democratic theory can become usable design material. The deck currently includes dilemmas such as losers' consent, legitimacy, resistance, consensus and meta-consensus, factions and parties, the boundaries of the demos, and democracy's relation to anti-democratic forces. It connects these to activities such as voting, deliberation, protest, civil disobedience, legal action, organising, listening, co-creation, and dialogue across disagreement. The central hypothesis is that the dilemmas can function as larp "conflict engines": not merely topics to teach, but structures that generate narrative tension and meaningful player action.

The cards were developed for a workshop format, and both the workshop and the cards are under development. They were initially tested at the 2026 Knutpunkt workshop, Designing Narratively Interesting Larp Democracy. There, participants were invited to explore whether a more nuanced understanding of democracy could produce drama rather than make larp feel procedural or dry. The current deck is best understood as an early design tool and precursor to the WP7 Democracy by Design toolkit, rather than as a finished or fully evaluated method.

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Appendices

Appendix 1: Larps currently under development as part of WP3 work

Incomplete list, due to an ongoing process

HOT SHOTS

Designers	*Current status*	*First run*	*Number of runs*	*Available at*	*Publication(s)*
Fuoco Balduzzi, Chaos League	*Test run as full larp*				

Hot Shots was designed to explore a specific question about deliberation in larp: how do players engage with a collective decision-making process when everyone already knows the outcome? Many larps stage group decisions as contests where players argue to win, and the tension lies in the result. This design removes that incentive on purpose. It asks whether the emotional and relational side of deliberation (loyalty, guilt, blame, affection, betrayal) comes to the foreground once no one needs to win the argument. The setting was chosen to be tonally far from the arenas we usually think of as political (councils, parliaments or town halls) Deliberation is a skill people use, and need to develop, in the everyday groups they belong to teams, workplaces, friendships, families. Placing it in a whimsical, drama-forward sports scandal presents deliberation as a social competence that is always in use, not a procedure reserved for politics.

Hot Shots is a chamber larp for 3–5 players that runs in about an hour online. The players are members of an elite sports team a few hours before the final. A party scandal has just gone viral, and the Coach demands that one of them take the fall at a press conference in thirty minutes. The stakes are careers and contracts: severe for the characters, but playful and manageable for the players. Before play begins, the facilitator openly draws the scapegoat. Players deliberate as if the choice were still open. In the final minutes, they must make the predetermined outcome make sense within the fiction, through sacrifice, persuasion, debt or threat. What's new is using a transparent, predetermined outcome as the central mechanic, which shifts the focus from *what* the group decides to *how* it gets there. Because the draw removes the drive to play to win, the characters have to carry the game. Each character has concrete stakes, hidden baggage and a protective bond with a teammate, so the friction runs on attachment as much as on accusation.

BUNKER 101

Designers	Current status	First run	Number of runs	Available at	Publication(s)
Fuoco Balduzzi, Alessandro Giovannucci, Andrea Giovannucci, Daniele Bergonzi, Chiara Marta Federica Sofia Cappiello, Martina Di Caro -Chaos League	Finished	July 2026	5	https://chaosleague.org/bunker-101-larp/	

Bunker 101 – The Aftermath is a large-scale larp for 125 participants, played over three days at Bunker Soratte, near Rome. It is set in the last human community on Earth, a sealed underground society that has survived almost a century since the nuclear war of 1959 under a system inherited from its founders. *Bunker 101* doesn't isolate one moment of deliberation. It simulates a whole society that functions. Its ethics are questionable and its circumstances dystopian, yet it keeps working. The game takes place during the three days before the Reboot, a risky procedure that must succeed for the community to survive and requires the sacrifice of the team who will perform it.

The first way it is relevant to democracy and design around democracy is its working political system. The design deliberately avoids what is often called "larp democracy," reducing the process to a search for general consensus with little impact. The Synergy is the bunker's parliament: thirty delegates plus a President, a Chairman and the Outgoing President. The delegates come from three parties, and none of them is framed as the "right" one. Players have huge agency over what is proposed, amended, negotiated and voted on. A presidential election takes place during play. The Synergy's decisions affects the game world directly. It sets the criteria for the Schneider Scale, the social classification that divides citizens into GREEN and RED. It decides who may receive licences, and it can change how the Reboot Crew is selected.

Passing a law is not the end of the process. Every law has to go through the bureaucracy and the offices responsible for putting it into practice. This separates legislative from executive power, and much of the political play happens in the gap between the two: between what the Synergy intends and what the commissions actually apply.

For this reason, the act of writing laws became central to play. Laws had to be drafted precisely, with close attention to how each word might be interpreted by the offices that would apply them, by opponents looking for weaknesses, and by citizens looking for loopholes. A key theme that came out of play is that democracy is also a matter of form.

This brings us to bureaucracy. In the bunker, forms, licences, classifications and commissions decide which rights citizens have: who may form a union, who may have a child, who is protected and who is sent into danger. Bureaucracy works as an instrument of oppression. It also works as a tool for resisting that oppression. Finding a loophole, reinterpreting a procedure or filing the right request can sometimes achieve change that ethical argument alone could not. The design treats administrative literacy as a political skill.

Then there is interdependence. The bunker is a system of institutions working alongside each other, like cogs in a machine that must keep running. Every citizen holds both a Lifeline Duty, which keeps the bunker physically alive, and a Civic Duty, such as the Synergy, the commissions, the Diner or the Nursery. Nobody can opt out of the collective, and no single faction can govern alone. Compromise is therefore a central theme: it is rarely ideal, often uncomfortable, and necessary for society to survive.

SANDLEFORD

Designers	*First Run*	*Number of runs*	*Current status*	*Available at*	*Publication(s)*
Annika Waern *Jon Back* *Fuoco Balduzzi*	*Knutpunkt, April 2026*	*3*	*Published, under evaluation*		-

This larp was designed in response to a gap identified in WP2 (Waern et al. 2026) in current design approaches to democratic engagement in larp. While many larps implement collective decision-making processes, it is harder to depict the process of moving beyond the decision to its implementation. The challenge also persists in modern democracies, where it is common, perhaps in particular for populist parties in local settings, to promise to undo decisions that have been made by the former majority rule.

Sandleford is an educational larp set in a fictional mining town that has democratically decided to relocate because the town has become unsafe. The decision was legitimate and soon becomes irreversible; the game begins after it has been made. Players take the roles of local residents meeting through recurring pub-quiz nights as they encounter its consequences. The exploration is therefore not primarily about deliberation or changing an outcome. Rather, it examines democratic aftermath: how people resist, accept, adapt to, or continue to contest a decision while remaining part of a shared democratic society.

The design asks how loss, disagreement, compromise, constrained agency, and continued civic engagement can be experienced socially and affectively; rather than only discussed in the abstract. The game consists of first playing, and then a structured embodied debrief, where both parts are integral parts of the game design. The combination of scenario and debrief are intended to explicate and make the tensions available for reflection and discussion.

THE ASSEMBLY

Designers	Current status	First run	Number of runs	Available at	Publication(s)
Sarah Lynne Bowman, PerOla Öberg. Josephine Rydberg. and Kjell Hedgard Hugaas	Finished December 2025	Nov 2025, Stockholm Scenario Festival (2 runs)	12 runs so far: online on Zoom and VR, in-person in Sweden, Poland, Germany, and Finland	https://scenariofestival.se/archive-old/scenarios-2025/the-assembly/	Bowman et al. (in press): Design paper for the ISAGA proceedings; Tismanariu et al, (in press): mixed method longitudinal study on 1 online run

The Assembly is a collaboration between members of UU, LARPifiers, and the Domain Expert Panel. The larp was designed based on work in WP2 that established learning objectives focused upon fostering democratic communication skills, as well as best practices in deliberative events and larp design (Bowman et al. 2026). The larp is about community members engaging in democratic deliberation about issues related to tensions between bodily autonomy and public

safety. The larp takes place in a fictional version of Sweden. People from diverse backgrounds and political perspectives have been invited to take part in a citizen's assembly to share their thoughts and feelings about legalizing the psychoactive substance psilocybin. The question they seek to answer is, "Should psilocybin be legalized or criminalized? Under what conditions?" At the end of the scenario, the community members collectively construct guidelines that will be considered at the next parliamentary session.

MIDSUMMER IN WALDEN

Designers	Current status	First run	Number of runs	Available at	Publication(s)
Antonio Casado da Rocha, Sarah Lynne Bowman, and Brent A. Ferguson	Full script in development	Planned for The Smoke in London January 2027	3 runs planned at festivals and conferences in the UK (The Smoke), Finland (Stoori, and Spain	TBD	TBD

Midsummer in Walden is a collaboration between project members from UU and volunteers from University of Basque Country in Spain and Brunel University in the UK. The larp was created from the design challenge of combining verbal deliberative elements with more embodied, affect-based modes of interaction. Research will focus on the effects on deliberative skill building, as well as other insights participants have connected to democracy that are related to themes and setting.

Midsummer in Walden is a historically inspired live-action role-playing game set at Walden Pond, Massachusetts, during the summer of 1847. The writer and activist Henry David Thoreau has lived there in his cabin for almost two years. He senses that his experiment may have fulfilled its purpose and invites friends from Concord to a midsummer gathering before deciding whether to leave.

The larp images a midsummer celebration in which luminaries of the Transcendentalist movement come together to discuss spirituality, politics, ecology, social responsibility, and the purpose of life. The scenario includes scene vignettes that take place over the course of several days, in which central figures in this literary community engage in various activities, including guided meditations and deliberations over social responsibility during antebellum America.

These scenes explore non-traditional relationships, class struggles, oppression based on race/ethnicity, and gender roles, while probing deeper questions about consciousness and humankind's relationship to the natural world. Play will include discussion, but also more embodied practices such as flashbacks in which participants embody experiences within the environment, while accompanied by live improvisational music inspired by the Romantic period.

These characters represent distinct generations, social positions, and ways of understanding the relationship between individual conscience and collective responsibility, embodying the spirit of inquiry and choice about what lives we choose to live, and which ones we leave behind. While the events take place in an idyllic setting, the stakes of this exchange hint towards broader tensions relevant to the past, present, and future of American democracy.

Characters include Ralph Waldo and Lydian Jackson Emerson, Bronson and the young Louisa May Alcott, Elizabeth Peabody, Margaret Fuller, Nathaniel Hawthorne, and Walt Whitman. Inspired in part by Deranged (Bergmann Hamming and Bergmann Hamming 2015), Byromania (Gräslund and Hultman 2025), Gothic (Avalon Larp Studio 2023), and Metropolis (Torner 2012).

Appendix 2: Theoretical Framework of Embodied Debriefing

Current citation: Szatkowska, W. (forthcoming). Theoretical Framework of Embodied Debriefing. Manuscript to be submitted to *Simulation & Gaming*.

Abstract

This article systematizes embodied practices that support reflection during debriefing. Drawing on a phenomenological focus on lived experience and embodied cognition, it proposes a framework for embodied debriefing: a guided process occurring during and/or after gameplay in which participants reflect on their experiences and examine their outcomes through bodily movement, sensory awareness, gestures, interactions with objects, and engagement with the physical or simulated environment. This approach extends conventional, primarily verbal understandings of debriefing by treating bodily experience as relevant as intellectual processing.

The framework was developed using a constructive grounded theory approach. In the study identified and analyzed over 120 exercises incorporating elements of embodiment and used in the debriefing of games in educational or leisure settings. Exercises were included in the study under criteria: (1) documented application in a debriefing process; (2) an explicit connection to reflective cycles or the processing of post-game experiences; (3) sufficient information about the structure and course of the activity; and (4) a format that extended beyond verbal responses to facilitators' questions or prompts, whether undertaken individually, in pairs, or in groups. The resulting framework comprises two principal branches: insight-out and outside-in. Insight-out practices involve working with the body and with knowledge grounded in bodily experiences and somatic cues; in these practices, the body becomes the object of reflection. Outside-in practices involve the active participation of the body in reflecting on and integrating experience. Accordingly, the body may function in debriefing as a source of information, a tool for processing experience, and a means of rehearsing or enacting new insights. The insight-out branch includes two activity clusters: inquiry-based work and body work. The outside-in branch comprises five clusters: writing, art-making, performance, movement, and tactile practices.

The analysis identified several purposes for using embodied practices in debriefing: generating new insights, developing alternative ways of processing insights, accessing embodied and subconscious layers of experience, processing emotions and supporting nervous-system regulation, and embodying and testing newly developed insights. It also distinguished eight types of reflection: self-reflection on values, self-reflection on emotions, self-reflection on in-game behaviors, self-reflection on personal change, reflection on changes in the world, self-reflection on off-game behaviours, reflection on in-game systems, and reflection on off-game (complex) systems. The study offers a conceptual and analytical framework for describing, designing, and researching embodied practices in debriefing. It demonstrates that debriefing can be understood not only as a discursive process of discussing gameplay, but also as an embodied process in which bodily awareness, movement, material engagement, and enactment contribute to the generation, processing, and integration of reflective insights.

Appendix 3: Theoretical Grounding of Embodied Debriefing in Simulation Games

Current citation: Szatkowska, W., Cwil, M., Kriz, W. C., (forthcoming). Theoretical Grounding of Embodied Debriefing. In Kikkawa, T., de Wijse-Van Heeswijk, M., Sugiura, J., Kriz, W. (eds) *Simulation and Gaming for Societal Change: Connecting Scientific Foundations, Practice, and Emerging AI Technologies*, Springer Nature. Accepted.

Abstract

Debriefing is a central mechanism through which simulation and gaming experiences are transformed into action. However, debriefing practices remain predominantly verbal and cognitively oriented, potentially overlooking the bodily and sensory dimensions through which gameplay is experienced. This chapter develops embodied debriefing as a conceptual approach that extends reflective practice by incorporating bodily, sensory, motor, and material forms of engagement. Drawing on embodied, embedded, extended, and enactive (4E) cognition, phenomenological perspectives, and theories of experiential and reflective learning, the chapter conceptualizes the body as both a source of information and a medium for processing and rehearsing insights generated through gameplay. It presents a range of embodied debriefing practices, including somatic, spatial, tactile, artistic, and performance-based activities, and considers their potential to support meaning-making and knowledge transfer. The chapter further emphasizes that reflection may occur during, after, and in preparation for future action, suggesting that embodied debriefing can complement iterative approaches to reflection in simulation gaming. Rather than proposing a single standardized method, the chapter positions embodied debriefing as a concept in development and identifies key directions for future research concerning the relationship between game medium, reflective practices, activity combinations, and participant characteristics. Research through Design is proposed as a promising approach for further developing and empirically investigating embodied debriefing.

Appendix 4: Study and Design of Parody Politician Accounts

Current citation: Feng, Jingpeng, and Jon Back. 2026. *Designing for Playful Participation in Political Discourse on X through Parody Politician Accounts*. Unpublished manuscript.

Abstract

Political parody can encourage participation in political discourse and open space for alternative political possibilities. Parody politician accounts (PPAs) bring these possibilities into social media through role-play and platform appropriation. We conducted a netnography study by reading 241 posts and associated comments from 14 English-language PPAs on X through the theoretical lens of frame analysis. The findings informed three PPA design examples, which were discussed in critique workshops with 11 participants. The analysis identified three design-relevant insights: PPAs construct parody through curated adjacency; access to the play frame is uneven; and misrecognition can interrupt or redirect play. These insights led to three design suggestions for playful participation in political discourse on X through PPAs: critical bouncing, playful opposition, and sustainable play. This paper contributes to HCI by reframing PPAs as emergent playful interactivity and offering design knowledge for playful political participation through existing social media infrastructures.

Appendix 5: The Assembly: Designing a Role-playing Intervention to Foster Skills in Democratic Deliberation

Current citation: Bowman, Sarah Lynne, PerOla Öberg, Kjell Hedgard Hugaas, and Josephine Rydberg. In press. "*The Assembly:* Designing a Role-playing Intervention to Foster Skills in Democratic Deliberation." Proceedings of *ISAGA Conference 2026*, Springer Lecture Notes in Computer Science.

Abstract

This paper will discuss the design strategies and assessment protocol for the live action role-playing game (larp) *The Assembly*. Democracies face an increasingly polarized landscape in which community members from different backgrounds and political beliefs have trouble communicating respectfully without intensifying conflicts. These issues have contributed to what many experience as a breakdown of civil engagement in the public sphere. Democracies need approaches to discourse that foster clear expression of viewpoints, deep listening, openness to the views of others, and the willingness to change one's mind on complex political issues. Such an exchange of relevant considerations requires that no perspectives be suppressed, but rather that voices that are otherwise marginalized be heard and respected. The Assembly was designed based on best practices and empirical research on deliberative events and transformative role-playing game design to model such skills in a 3–4-hour experience. This paper will describe the design process contextualized within simulation and role-playing game studies, further describing the framework for longitudinal mixed-method assessment developed by the research team, with results reserved for future work.

Appendix 6: Practicing Empathy in The Assembly: A Mixed Methods Study of a Deliberative Larp Intervention

Current citation: Tismanariu, Iléana, Meghan Gardner, Alexandra Ciubotaru, Kjell Hedgard Hugaas, and Sarah Lynne Bowman. In press. "Practicing Empathy in The Assembly: A Mixed Methods Study of a Deliberative Larp Intervention." In *Immersion, Liveness, and the Qualities of Experience: Having a Lar*p, edited by Roy Hanney. Routledge.

Abstract

This chapter examines how deliberative live action role-playing games (larps) can support the practice of empathy and shape the participants' capacity for deliberation in the context of contemporary democratic challenges. Focusing on a single online run of the deliberative larp The Assembly, the study draws on quantitative surveys, qualitative interviews, and observational data gathered before, during, and after play. Information from the survey established participant context, deliberative orientations, empathy-related traits, and motivation; observations captured deliberative behaviour during play; and interviews explored participants' later interpretations of the experience.

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